14.3.4 Customizing environment variables

The first customization we could apply is an environment variable to activate the `staging` Spring profile for Catalog Service. Most customizations can be applied via patches following a merge strategy. Much like Git merges changes from different branches, Kustomize produces final Kubernetes manifests with changes coming from different `Kustomization` files (one or more bases and an overlay).

A best practice when defining Kustomize patches is to keep them small and focused. To customize environment variables, create a patch-env.yml file within the staging overlay for Catalog Service (kubernetes/applications/catalog-service/staging). We need to specify some contextual information so Kustomize can figure out where to apply the patch and how to merge the changes. When the patch is for customizing a container, Kustomize requires us to specify the kind and name of the Kubernetes resource (that is, `Deployment`) and the name of the container. This customization option is called a *strategic merge patch*.

Listing 14.11 A patch for customizing environment variables

```
apiVersion: apps/v1
kind: Deployment
metadata:
  name: catalog-service
spec:
  template:
    spec:
      containers:
        - name: catalog-service
          env:
            - name: SPRING_PROFILES_ACTIVE      ❶
              value: prod
```

❶ Defines which Spring profiles should be activated